

Expenses Reporting Tool for an IT Consultancy

Project Management (GEP)
Assignment 4: Final Document

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Bachelor's Thesis



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1 Context

This is a Bachelor's Thesis within the Software Engineering specialization of the Computer Engineering Degree, provided by the Barcelona School of Informatics at the Polytechnic University of Catalonia.

The project corresponds to modality B, as it is developed in a professional context in collaboration with FSP Consulting Services Limited. Consequently, this thesis is supervised under a dual-mentorship structure involving Marc Oriol Hilari, a lecturer in the specialization, and Sergio Alejandro Lobig Machado, a Senior Cloud Engineer at FSP.

1.1 Introduction

Organizations often hold company events which employees are required to attend. Travel to these events inevitably results in employees incurring various expenditures, such as flights, accommodation, and meals. As long as these expenses are business-related and not for personal use, companies typically offer reimbursement.

This is a common scenario within FSP's Barcelona team. FSP is a UK-founded private technology consultancy that has established Barcelona as one of its several office locations. As expected, the Barcelona-based team frequently travels to the UK for corporate events, meetings and collaborative work, often struggling with high expenditures along the way.

The current method for managing these expense claims relies on a manual and document-based workflow. To do that, Barcelona's team must gather all tickets, record them in Excel spreadsheets, and email them to the Finance Department for processing and approval.

1.2 Key Concepts

The goal of this thesis is to apply and demonstrate the knowledge and competencies acquired throughout the author's Computer Engineering Degree. As a result, this document may contain jargon that could be challenging for readers without a background in this field. To facilitate reading of this thesis, the description of technical terms in this documentation is listed below and can be consulted as needed.

Expense Report Workflow

The full process of reporting an expense includes capturing the receipt, uploading the file, extracting information, submitting the report, and approving or rejecting the reimbursement.

Full-stack Application

An application composed of two components: frontend and backend. The frontend handles the visual and interactive application layer, while the backend manages its internal server logic.

Pipeline

A set of ordered automated tasks executed sequentially.

Bottlenecks

Network traffic congestion.

Cloud Computing Platform

A virtual service that offers virtual resources for software development that were traditionally provided physically.

RESTful API

API is the communication system between the frontend and backend, while REST (Representational State Transfer) is a widely recognized architectural pattern for designing APIs. REST standardizes API usage through uniform conventions, making it intuitive and straightforward for developers to understand and manage.

1.3 Problems to Solve

The existing hand-operated expense reporting system at FSP introduces substantial inefficiencies for both employees and the Finance department. Specifically, employees spend excessive time entering detailed receipt information in Excel spreadsheets. Concurrently, the Finance Department undertakes labour-intensive work in verifying outdated spreadsheets.

Moreover, from FSP's perspective, this manual data entry is prone to human error. According to the company's historical data, approximately 30% of submitted reports require manual correction due to transcription errors or missing information. Consequently, this not only increases the risk of inaccuracy but also results in expenses being delivered to the wrong person.

Quantitatively, FSP's Barcelona team of 25 employees departs for the UK 2-4 times annually, generating an average of 8 receipts per person per trip. Each employee spends around 15 minutes on a manual expense report, while the Finance Department (composed of 4 people) takes 20 minutes to review. Collectively, this unproductive task accounts for roughly 175 lost hours per year and prolongs reimbursement cycles by about 18 days.

Therefore, the time consumed in this burdensome activity could be considerably reduced, enabling highly skilled employees to focus on activities that deliver higher value to the company. Hence, there is a need to optimize FSP's personnel investment.

1.4 Proposed Solution

FSP clearly lacks a more intelligent, automated expense management strategy to prevent employee frustration and guarantee accurate reimbursement of business expenses. This project aims to develop an automated web application that allows employees to manage, report, and submit expenses seamlessly on a single platform.

This application streamlines the entire workflow, offering effortless receipt uploads, AI-automated data extraction and efficient verification and approval processes. The primary goal is to simplify the previous expenses management workflow, optimizing time and effort for all parties, reducing human error, and ensuring information is transmitted securely and efficiently to the appropriate approver.

1.5 Stakeholders

With the problem and solution established, all parties involved in this project (also known as stakeholders) are identified below.

1.5.1 Product Owner

The Product Owner is responsible for understanding the client's interests and communicating them effectively to the application development team. Their principal role is to maximize the value of the final product from the client's point of view. They define the product's vision and requirements, aligning the app's features with the client's interests throughout the development lifecycle.

In this case, Sergio Alejandro Lobig Machado serves as Product Owner, as he is the only representative of FSP in this project.

1.5.2 Thesis Director

The Bachelor's Thesis Director oversees the academic aspects of this project, prioritizing the successful fulfilment of all degree requirements. Marc Oriol Hilari fills this role, consistently monitoring progress to verify that all required technical and transversal competencies are achieved and demonstrated at the end of this project.

1.5.3 Development Team

The development team is responsible for implementing the entire application—from initial pipelines and database design and technology stack decisions to final testing and product deployment. At this moment, only the thesis author takes charge of this role. However, it does not rule out the possibility of extending and upgrading this project in the future, thus adding new developers to the team.

1.5.4 FSP's Barcelona Team

This application addresses FSP's Barcelona Team needs; as a consequence, they become the primary beneficiary of the product and are the application's end-users.

1.5.5 Finance Department

This group refers to the FSP's Finance department, which is responsible for reviewing and approving or rejecting submitted expense reports and authorising reimbursements. Hence, they also become part of the application's end-users.

1.5.6 IT Administrators

IT administrators review and verify users' logs for security purposes and solve any technical problems. This collective is identified in FSP's IT department.

2 Justification

Given the project’s focus on developing an expense management tool for FSP (Section 1.5), a detailed market analysis of existing applications is conducted. Through this analysis, the application’s final features are established by aligning market offerings with FSP’s interests. At the same time, this process clarifies project justification and establishes the correct scope.

2.1 Market Analysis

The market already offers a bunch of available expense management applications. However, this analysis compares only a subset of the leading platforms [1]. Conducting a current market analysis helps identify industry gaps and standards and determine the most essential application functionalities.

To establish a baseline, the analyzed platforms are assumed to incorporate fundamental features of simplified expense management. This includes centralized expense data, digital expense management and reporting, streamlined information submissions, and secure login access through the company’s employee account.

To delve deeper into the main differences of available market offerings, consider Table 2.1.1, which shows a comparative overview of these platforms. Green cells indicate features that the application offers, while red cells indicate the opposite. Each platform’s pricing appears in the final row. These costs are only an estimation, since each model offers a customised plan.

The detailed analysis of Table 2.1.1 reveals two common industry features: AI-powered data extraction and OCR technology. The AI model serves as an automatic extraction tool for selecting relevant information from receipts, and OCR technology automates the conversion of a text-content image into a machine-readable text [2].

Incorporating an AI model is essential for this project to streamline expense data extraction. The final product will integrate this tool, as outlined previously in Section 1.4. This approach replaces the previous tedious manual data entry and reduces human error. Nevertheless, OCR technology is intentionally omitted in this implementation, since the AI model already includes image data extraction.

Despite the strengths of these solutions, there are clear differences in their target markets and secondary features. For example, SAP Concur dominates the large enterprise sector, but it is often criticized for its non-intuitive user interface and high-cost plans.

In contrast, Zoho Expense and Expensify primarily target small businesses, offering more user-friendly interfaces, more affordable pricing, and additional features not included in SAP Concur. Additionally, Payhawk introduces a feature not offered by previous platforms: automated VAT receipt extraction [3] [4].

The last column of Table 2.1.1 shows all the included features in the ongoing application. These are the AI model integration (as mentioned earlier), an intuitive user interface to minimize the learning curve and reporting time, plus a spending limit configuration to prevent misuse of the application.

However, as a small private company, FSP is not interested in all available market features. Customized approval processes lie beyond FSP's needs. Global reimbursements are unnecessary (expenses are added to monthly salaries). Virtual cards serve no purpose for the Barcelona team. Finally, automated VAT extraction lacks relevance.

Considering the last feature in Table 2.1.1, FSP's demand an innovative feature not supported by existing platforms: real-time email notifications. This functionality alerts employees when an expense report has been rejected or approved, and notifies approvers when a report is submitted and pending review. This feature is essential at FSP, enabling employees to focus on core tasks while awaiting review results and freeing Finance from constantly checking pending reports.

Feature	SAP Concur	Zoho Expense	Expensify	Payhawk	FSP's own application
AI-powered data extraction					
OCR technology					
Intuitive UI					
Spending limit configuration					
Customized approval processes					
Global reimbursements					
Virtual cards					
Automated VAT extraction					
Real-time notification service					
Estimated cost per month	€21.90/user	€5.26/user	€7.88/user	Customized pricing	

Table 2.1.1: Comparative analysis of leading expense management solutions. [Own creation]

2.2 Project Justification

At this point, the development of this application can be justified on several grounds, perfectly aligning the author's academic objectives with the FSP's business needs.

First, there is an evident need for FSP to find a better solution. Although numerous excellent options exist, none of them fit perfectly with FSP's specific context. All of the applications cited in Section 2.1 provide excessive features and lack a critical functionality required: the email notification service.

Second, as mentioned in Section 1.3, FSP has 25 employees in the Barcelona team and 4 in the Finance department. Therefore, external applications demand annual costs ranging from €1,830.48 (Zoho Expense) to €7,621.20 (SAP Concur). By contrast, an internal application achieves return on investment within 2-8 years (based on the project budget defined in Section 6.1.4). Thus, adopting third-party solutions results in overspending for FSP.

Third, this project marks the author's first independent application development. Consequently, it is a valuable opportunity to demonstrate key Software Engineering competencies in practice, including:

- Translating business needs into functional and non-functional technical requirements.
- Developing a full-stack application based on a decoupled system architecture composed of 6 layers: infrastructure, business logic, application, API, external parties, and interface.
- Designing CI/CD pipelines in the code repository employing DevOps practices (detailed in Section 3.2.2).
- Employing external Azure cloud resources.

3 Scope

As stated in Section 1.4, the main goal of this project is to **develop a web application that addresses FSP’s problems and offers tailored features to its specific context**. To better achieve this objective, this section provides a more detailed description of the project goal, specifies the application’s functional requirements, and concretizes the potential obstacles and risks.

3.1 Objectives

For a clearer understanding of the project scope and easier evaluation of its completion, the project’s objective is broken down into smaller, more manageable sub-objectives:

SO1. Design the technology stack and the database system of the application.

SO2. Develop a full-stack web application.

SO3. Design a scalable expense upload pipeline to extract relevant data directly using an external AI model.

SO4. Use a cloud computing platform to integrate external application resources.

SO5. Maintain a clean, reusable, maintainable, and high-quality code throughout the application development.

3.2 Requirements

Considering the application’s features defined based on current market analysis (Section 2.1), this section introduces the application’s requirements to ensure a high-quality product is delivered at the end of this project.

In Software Engineering, requirements are categorized into two main groups: functional and non-functional. The former defines what features the application provides, while the latter describes how those features are delivered [5]. As a result, the requirements of this project are defined following this structure.

3.2.1 Functional Requirements

Due to the constrained thesis timeline, the application’s functional requirements are prioritized applying the MoSCoW methodology. By doing this, all core functionalities are delivered early. MoSCoW classifies requirements into four main groups: **Must have**, **Should have**, **Could have** and **Won’t have**.

Must have: requirements that are critical for the core application functionality.

MH1: The system must centralize expense data on a single platform.

MH2: The system must provide effortless receipt uploads and drag-and-drop.

MH3: The system must automate data extraction from receipts using an AI model.

MH4: The system must allow users to review and correct the automatically extracted data.

MH5: The system must enable a simple submission of expense reports to a predefined approver.

MH6: The system must require users to log in through their company's account.

MH7: The system must implement role-based access control with two main roles:

Employees: Access to the basic application features.

Admins: Access to all employee features, plus the additional admin-only features.

MH8: The system could send email notifications to the report creator when the report is approved or rejected and to the administrator when new reports are pending review.

Should have: requirements that are relevant for the application functionality, but permit a certain delay in complete achievement.

SH1: The system should provide a search bar and filters for uploaded expenses.

SH2: The system should allow users to group multiple expenses into a single report for submission.

SH3: The system should display a history of submitted reports, categorized as:

- Pending review
- Approved
- Rejected

SH4: The system should allow admin users to approve or reject submitted reports.

SH5: The system should display to admin users a history of reviewed reports.

Could have: requirements that enhance the application usability and are fulfilled if time permits.

CH1: The system could allow users to edit report information.

CH2: The system could provide a search bar to find specific reports.

CH3: The system could allow admins to set the expenses budget limit for those employees under their supervision.

Won't have: requirements that are irrelevant and will not be included in the application.

WH1: The system won't provide virtual payment cards.

WH2: The system won't handle reimbursement transactions.

WH3: The system won't allow admins to customize approval processes.

WH4: The system won't provide VAT receipt extractions.

3.2.2 Non-Functional Requirements

The subsequent requirements fall under the non-functional category.

NFR1. The application must provide real-time updates on expense processing status.

When the AI model processes a receipt in the backend, the UI updates the expenses dashboard to reflect the new status in less than **1 second**.

NFR2. The application must offer an interactive, responsive, and user-friendly UI.

The UI must be **interactive**; hence, every user action should trigger a response [6]. The UI must also be **responsive**, meaning it adapts automatically to any device or screen size [7]. Finally, the UI must be intuitive and easy to use (**user-friendly**); a new user should not spend more than **5 minutes** uploading, reviewing, and saving an expense.

NFR3. The application must ensure high performance and availability.

Upon user login, the application should load the prior uploaded expenses within **3 seconds**. Other basic user interactions (e.g., saving expense information, deleting expenses) should trigger an application response in under **500ms**. Additionally, the application should be available **24 hours** a day, **365 days** a year.

NFR4. The application must support scalability as the company grows.

The automated expense extraction workflow should support **20 receipt uploads** without overloading the server.

NFR5. The application must guarantee compliance with GDPR.

The application must store only relevant data and use an external cloud platform (this project will use Azure) that meets GDPR standards for data manipulation (Azure SQL Database) and user access (Microsoft Entra ID).

NFR6. The application must enable a more efficient expense management process and a streamlined approval workflow.

The application must reduce expense processing time from the current 15 minutes (manual process) to **5 minutes** maximum, achieving a **66.6%** efficiency gain. Additionally, the reimbursement cycle is shortened by **50%** from its current duration.

NFR7. The application must be designed to facilitate future AI model integrations.

The application must provide a separate logic for the AI model integration, simplifying the integration of new models by updating a single endpoint.

NFR8. The project must support automated deployment and testing.

The application must implement Continuous Integration (CI) and Continuous Deployment (CD) pipelines to follow DevOps principles. When a new implementation is pulled into the source code, pipelines enforce thorough testing of the updated version to prevent bugs while ensuring high-quality code and fast delivery.

3.3 Obstacles and Risks

Identifying obstacles and risks is crucial for more precise initial timeline estimation (further established in Section 5.4). Hence, this section outlines obstacles and risks that may hinder project execution. The analysis of their probability, impact and mitigation strategies is covered in detail in Section 5.5.

3.3.1 Coding Bugs

As the application development progresses, certain coding bugs will inevitably emerge, requiring additional time to fix. Given the high probability of encountering these risks, minor delays in the project are expected.

3.3.2 Tight Project Deadlines

The project timeline is constrained by the thesis deadline. Significant delays may affect the final product from fully meeting all defined requirements, representing a major challenge for the author. Core application features will therefore be prioritized (based on MoSCoW requirements classification) to deliver a high-value solution for FSP.

3.3.3 Lack of Experience in Certain Technologies

The two previous situations are quite common in real-world engineering practice, and this one is no exception. Exploring and applying new technologies is a constant challenge to a software engineer's daily work. Accordingly, time for learning and becoming familiar with these technologies is factored into the project timeline.

3.3.4 Company's Licenses and Security Permissions

This project is executed within FSP's environment. The company's strategies to prevent cyberattacks may require developers to ask for permissions when installing new tools and resources. This supposes some constraints for the project, as certain installations are required throughout the development.

4 Methodology

The ScrumBan methodology is adopted throughout the project and is supported by a selection of monitoring tools. In addition, a set of validation methods is applied to demonstrate the achievements of the defined objectives (See Section 3.1).

4.1 Development Methodology

This project applies the Agile methodology, specifically based on the ScrumBan framework. ScrumBan is a hybrid approach of Scrum and Kanban. Scrum features role assignments, focuses on team coordination, and aims to increment the product's value through predefined iterations (known as sprints). Kanban emphasizes flexibility with continuous workflows, incremental delivery, and strict work-in-progress (WIP) limits [8].

ScrumBan offers a wide range of options combining Scrum and Kanban methodologies, facilitating its adaptation to the project's context. The main roles defined for this project are a subset of Scrum roles: Product Owner and Development Team (their role descriptions and assignments are found in Section 1.5).

By contrast, the full development cycle reflects the Kanban continuous nature, omitting Scrum's fixed sprints and ceremonies. Since the development team consists of a single developer, traditional Scrum ceremonies such as sprint planning, sprint review, and sprint retrospective were simplified. Instead, regular meetings with the Product Owner are scheduled every 2 days throughout the project to monitor the process.

Before starting the practical implementation, a product backlog (from Scrum) is defined to prioritize the core application features. In addition, a maximum of **three product backlog tasks** is defined as **Work In Progress (WIP)**. Following Kanban's pull principles, the number of tasks in progress always reaches the WIP limit, adding next-step tasks if needed to support the continuous workflow.

4.2 Monitoring Tools

The upcoming monitoring tools in this section are used to facilitate the application of Agile methodology.

Git

A cloud version control system that allows multiple developers to work on the same project within a shared repository, and enables a single user to develop several features at the same time. These capabilities make Git essential for the Kanban's continuous flow principle, allowing developers to proceed with new tasks when the current one is blocked.

In Git, a repository is the location where the application's source code is stored. It serves as a project space where developers submit their code, allowing changes to be tracked throughout the development process. Using a Git repository for source code version control provides high availability since it is cloud-based.

Azure DevOps

Azure is a cloud platform that offers multiple tools; among them, two relevant monitoring tools are used for this project: the Git repository (established earlier) and the backlog dashboard, employed for product backlog management.

In the backlog, four statuses are assigned to tasks:

- **New:** A task that has been defined but is pending development, or a bug that is pending resolution.
- **Active:** A task that is currently in progress. As clarified in Section 4.1, there are always 3 tasks in Active status, according to the WIP limit.
- **Resolved:** A bug that has been fixed.
- **Closed:** A task that has been developed, integrated and tested.

Microsoft Teams

A communication tool used for conducting regular meetings with the Product Owner.

4.3 Validation Methods

As mentioned in Section 4.2, the development code is managed in a Git repository. In this repository, new implementations are developed in their own branch (named Type/Author/Feature) and are merged into the main branch via Pull Requests (PRs). Each PR triggers the CI/CD pipelines (as noted in Section 3.2.2) to compile, verify through rigorous testing, and build the new code.

In the CI/CD pipeline testing, both unit and integration tests are executed. Unit tests verify each component's behaviour functions as expected, while integration tests check that all components are properly connected. Additionally, unit tests must achieve at least 70% of code coverage to ensure effective testing.

Inside the code editor, Visual Studio Code extensions are installed from the beginning of code development. Before merging new code into the main branch, these extension tools must detect zero bugs and zero code smells (suspicious bug-prone code). Moreover, to demonstrate the time requirements established in NFR1-4 (Section 3.2.2), the browser's development tools will measure the application response times for each user interaction.

Finally, to ensure that the application aligns with the established requirements (see Section 3.2), tasks from the product backlog remain open until the Product Owner confirms that they meet the specified requirements. To support this process, regular meetings with the Product Owner (according to Section 4.1) are held to monitor development progress. At the same time, the thesis director will supervise the project to ensure compliance with academic standards.

5 Temporal Planning

This section introduces the initial **122-day** project plan, scheduled from February 18, 2026, to June 19, 2026. The total estimated effort for all defined tasks is **513 hours**.

According to Polytechnic University of Catalonia, the bachelor's thesis carries a workload of 18 ECTS credits, equivalent to 540 effort hours. The discrepancy between the total estimated effort of 513 hours and the expected 540 hours results in a built-in buffer of **27 hours** to accommodate potential setbacks.

5.1 Task Description

The key to achieving effective time planning lies in a thorough analysis of all tasks, their priorities and durations. This step facilitates proper task sequencing and resource allocation. For this reason, all tasks are outlined in this section and categorized into six main groups: project starting, project management, final project delivery, design, development, and frontend/backend development.

5.1.1 Project Starting

A solid project start requires a preliminary study and initial project definition. This aligns the project vision among all involved members and establishes a unified understanding of the project's scope and objectives. To achieve this, the subsequent tasks are defined:

PS1. Context and Scope

This task is divided into smaller sub-tasks:

- Analyze the current problem and identify all stakeholders.
- Define and propose a technical solution.
- Describe the project context and conduct a market study.
- Define the project scope in terms of objectives, requirements, obstacles, and risks.
- Select a pattern methodology to guide the entire project development.
- Select the monitoring and validation tools to be used in the project.

PS2. Temporal Planning

Identify all tasks and resources, design an initial Gantt diagram timeline, and define a risk management strategy.

PS3. Budget and Sustainability

Define a project budget and analyze the sustainability aspects of the proposed solution.

PS4. Initial Documentation

Consolidate the documentation from previous tasks into the definitive version of the initial documentation.

5.1.2 Project Management

Project management is essential for monitoring the project's progress and keeping the project on track.

PM1. Product Owner Meetings

Run regular meetings with the Product Owner to discuss the development progress, implementation priorities, and any issues.

PM2. Thesis Director Review Meetings

Meet with the thesis director every two weeks to ensure the project is progressing correctly.

PM3. Product Backlog Update

Refine, update, and maintain the product backlog, which always reflects the current project status.

5.1.3 Final Project Delivery

Tasks for completing product delivery are listed below.

FPD1. User Manual Documentation

Write a user manual for the application's end-users as a reference guide.

FPD2. Final Thesis Documentation

Write the bachelor's thesis final documentation intended for an academic audience. This task involves structuring the full project development, from planning and design to results and conclusions, maintaining an academic tone and standard.

FPD3. Final Demonstration Video

Record a final demonstration of the application once it is ready for use.

FPD4. Bachelor's Thesis Defense

Plan and prepare a final exposition to defend and justify the bachelor's thesis achievements, while demonstrating commitment to the academic standards.

5.1.4 Design

This preliminary design phase establishes a clear application architecture to guide the subsequent development phase.

DT1. Use Case Diagram

Analyze all users' interactions with the system and design a Use Case Diagram that illustrates all actors, use cases, and relationships between use cases.

DT2. Conceptual Model Diagram

Design the UML database diagram, clarifying all database entities, their attributes, and the relationships between them.

DT3. Technology Stack Decision

Select the technology to be used for each application layer and provide a clear technology selection documentation that serves as a guide for the application development phase.

DT4. Logical and Physical Architecture Design

Design the logical and physical application architecture.

The former describes how the implementation code is structured, including the purpose and role of each application layer. The latter explains how the application connects to external services and resources, both physical and virtual, and describes the function of each.

DT5. UI mockups Design

Deliver the mockup designs for each application page.

DT6. Security Design

Provide a security architecture design for user authentication, information submission and storage, and access control.

5.1.5 Development

Essential tasks for the application development are specified in this task group.

Dev0. Self-learning and study of unfamiliar technologies

Study and learn new application technologies in advance.

Dev1. Environment Configuration

Configure a ready-to-use environment to begin application development. This task involves installing Visual Studio Code, essential extensions, creating a Git repository, and similar setup tasks.

Dev2. Product Deployment

Release the final product for end-user availability.

Dev3. CI/CD Pipeline Implementation

Implement Continuous Integration and Continuous pipeline to automate compilation, unit and integration testing, and building of every updated code version.

Dev4. Logging and Monitoring

Set up logging and monitoring tools to track application performance and review logs.

Dev5. Git Repository Documentation

Maintain clear repository documentation, including an application setup guide, API contracts documentation, and meaningful code comments. This documentation is targeted to a technical audience.

5.1.6 Frontend and Backend Development

As a full-stack web application, the implementation is divided into two main areas. The frontend is responsible for the user interface (UI) and user experience (UX). The backend implements the complex implementations hidden in the frontend via a RESTful API and integrates external services.

This development stage requires both frontend and backend development. Since it covers a wide range of functionalities, it is divided into two subgroups: Expense and Report Development, and User Access Development.

Expense and Report Development

This group includes all tasks related to the application's core functionalities, namely the implementation of the expense and report features.

ER1. Expense Uploads

Develop a file submission feature where the frontend handles the expense drag-and-drop and upload interface, and the backend registers the uploaded expense in the database.

ER2. Uploaded Expenses Real-time Dashboard

Develop a visual dashboard to display all uploaded expenses with their real-time processing status, which can be:

- **Processing:** The expense is pending processing by the AI model.
- **Pending Review:** The AI model has successfully analyzed the expense, the uploader can now review it.
- **Completed:** The user has reviewed and completed all required information. The expense is ready for being included in a new or existing report.
- **Failed:** The AI couldn't extract data from the receipt (due to unavailability or unrecognized format).

ER3. AI-Extracted Expense Data Review and Correction

Develop a form page for users to review and edit AI-processed expenses and fill in missing required information. Once the expense information is saved, the database is updated with the corrected data.

ER4. Uploaded Expenses Deletion

Develop the expense deletion feature to delete one or multiple expenses at once, regardless of their current status. When the user confirms deletion, the respective expenses are marked as deleted in the database.

ER5. Expense Reports View, Creation, Edit, Submission, and Deletion

Develop report management functionalities (create, edit, submit, and delete reports) and the required RESTful API for synchronizing the database with the frontend changes.

User Access Development

The tasks described in this subgroup are contingent upon user authentication implementation before their execution can begin. It is important to note that administrators can set spending limits and manage and view submitted reports solely from employees under their supervision.

UA1. Company Email User Authentication

Develop the login feature that allows users to authenticate in the application through the company's email account, including:

1. User access verification.
2. (a) New account creation on first login.
(b) Existing user data recovery for returning users.

UA2. Role-based User Access

Develop the user role assignment (based on two main roles: regular employee or administrator) and expose only the corresponding role's functionalities.

UA3. Submitted Report Approval and Rejection

Develop a feature to allow administrators to review, approve, or reject submitted reports, and update the database accordingly.

UA4. Employee Spending Limit Configuration

Develop an admin-only interface to set employees' spending limits and record the changes in the database.

UA5. Submitted and Reviewed Expenses Records Visualization

Develop a dashboard displaying the records of both users' submitted reports and administrators' reviewed reports.

UA6. Email Notification Service Integration

Develop the email notification service to notify users when their submitted reports are reviewed, and to administrators when new reports are pending for their review.

5.1.7 Backend Development

The following tasks are implemented exclusively in the application backend logic.

BD1. RESTful API Backend Logic Implementation

Configure the backend architecture defined in the DT3 task and build a RESTful API to manage backend responsibilities through frontend requests.

BD2. Azure SQL Database Integration

Integrate Azure SQL Database with Entity Framework Core migrations to manage users' relevant information (e.g., extracted expense and report information, employees' hierarchy) and configure the initial database according to the diagram designed in DT2 task.

BD3. Azure Blob Storage Integration

Store original expense files using Azure Blob Storage.

BD4. Microsoft Document Intelligence AI Model Integration

Automate the expense data extraction through the Microsoft Document Intelligence AI model integration.

BD5. Automated AI-driven Data Extraction Pipeline

Integrate Event Grid, Service Bus, and Azure Function and implement a mechanized data extraction workflow that prevents bottlenecks during multiple simultaneous uploads:

1. Save the uploaded receipt file in the Blob Storage and store the receipt information in the SQL Database.
2. Detect the event using Azure Event Grid and route the expense file to the Service Bus queue.

3. Once the new expense is in the queue, trigger the Azure Function to process the receipt file using the integrated AI model.

BD6. Azure SignalR Real-time Notification Service Integration

Integrate SignalR to configure a SignalR Hub that sends real-time expense status updates, eliminating manual page refreshing whenever the AI processes a new receipt file.

BD7. Microsoft Entra ID User Authentication Integration

Handle employee authentication through the company email account by using Microsoft Entra ID integration.

5.1.8 Frontend Development

This category covers all tasks that require only frontend logic implementation.

FD1. Expenses Search and Filter

Develop visual tools that enable users to search uploaded expenses by name or filter them by category.

FD2. Reports Search

Provide a search bar to search specific reports by name.

5.2 Resources

Following the analysis of all required tasks for successful project completion, all necessary resources must be identified. Resources are divided into two main groups: human resources and physical resources. All human resources are listed in Table 5.2.1, specifying the responsible individual for each role. The physical resources are further categorized into software and hardware resources, and are identified and briefly described in Tables 5.2.2 and 5.2.3.

5.2.1 Human Resources

Resource ID	Role Name	Responsible Individual
PO	Product Owner	Sergio Alejandro Lobig Machado
TD	Thesis Director	Marc Oriol Hilari
GT	GEP Tutor	Eduard Balbuena Longo
DT	Development Team	Thesis author

Table 5.2.1: Human resources. [Own creation]

5.2.2 Physical Resources

Hardware Resources

Resource ID	Resource Name	Components
OS	Office Supplies	A table, a chair, electricity, internet, and office rental.
HW	Hardware Resources	A computer, two monitors, a mouse, and a keyboard.

Table 5.2.2: Hardware resources. [Own creation]

Software Resources

Resource ID	Resource Name	Description
GIT	Git	A version control tool for managing the source code repository.
AZR	Microsoft Azure Resources	Cloud services and resources: SQL Database, Blob Storage, AI model, Event Grid, Azure Function, Service Bus, SignalR, EntraID, and Azure DevOps (for repository and product backlog).
MCS	Microsoft Collaboration Tools	Communication and coordination platforms: Microsoft Teams, Calendar, Outlook, and Word.
VSC	Visual Studio Code	Source code editor with extensions and debugging tools.
FIB	FIB Platforms	Platforms from Barcelona School of Informatics(FIB): Racó, Atenea, FIB secretary, bachelor's thesis official website guide.
GM	Gmail	Email communication with university entities.
WEB	Web Browsers and Search Engines	Research Browsers: Mozilla Firefox, Google Chrome, Microsoft Edge.
OVL	Overleaf LaTeX Editor	Thesis formatting editor for final thesis documentation.
OT	Online Tools	Diagram design tools: Edraw, Draw.io, and Gantt Project.

Table 5.2.3: Software resources. [Own creation]

5.3 Summary of Tasks and Resources

See Table 5.3.1 for a summary of all defined tasks, including their identifiers, estimated effort in hours, any final-to-start dependencies with other tasks, and the required resources. The final-to-start dependency column indicates which task must be fully completed before the task in that row can begin.

ID	Name	Time (h)	Dependencies	Resources
PS	Project Starting	50		
PS1	Context and Scope	20	-	PO, TD, GT, DT, OS, HW, MCS, VSC, FIB, GM, WEB, OVL
PS2	Temporal Planning	10	PS1	PO, TD, GT, DT, OS, HW, MCS, VSC, FIB, GM, WEB, OVL, OT
PS3	Budget and Sustainability	10	PS2	PO, TD, GT, DT, OS, HW, MCS, VSC, FIB, GM, WEB, OVL
PS4	Initial Documentation	10	PS3	PO, TD, GT, DT, OS, HW, MCS, VSC, FIB, GM, WEB, OVL
PM	Project Management	46.5		
PM1	Product Owner Meetings	30.5	PS2	PO, DT, OS, HW, AZR, MCS, VSC
PM2	Thesis Director Review Meetings	8	-	DT, TD, OS, HW, AZR, VSC, FIB, GM, WEB
PM3	Product Backlog Update	8	PS2	DT, PO, OS, HW, AZR, WEB
FD	Final Product Delivery	56.5		
FPD1	User Manual Documentation	2	PM5	DT, OS, HW, VSC, WEB
FPD2	Final Thesis Documentation	30.5	-	DT, TD, OS, HW, FIB, GM, WEB, OVL, OT
FPD3	Final Demonstration Video	4	FPD2	DT, OS, HW, WEB
FPD4	Bachelor's Thesis Defense	20	FPD2	DT, TD, OS, HW, FIB, GM, WEB
DT	Design	16		
DT1	Use Case Diagram	2	PS1	DT, OS, HW, OT, WEB, MCS
DT2	Conceptual Model Diagram	4	PS1	DT, OS, HW, OT, WEB
DT3	Technology Stack Decision	2	PS1	DT, OS, HW, WEB, MCS
DT4	Logical and Physical Architecture Design	4	PS1	DT, OS, HW, WEB, MCS
DT5	UI mockups Design	2	DT1	DT, OS, HW, OT, WEB
DT6	Security Design	2	DT3, DT4	DT, OS, HW, WEB, MCS
Dev	Development	86		
Dev0	Self-learning and study of unfamiliar technologies	8	DT3	DT, OS, HW, WEB
Dev1	Environment Configuration	2	DT2, DT5, DT6	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
Dev2	Product Deployment	8	UA4, UA5, UA6	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
Dev3	CI/CD Pipeline Implementation	20	BD7	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
Dev4	Logging and Monitoring	8	Dev2	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
Dev5	Git Repository Documentation	40	Dev1	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
Frontend and Backend Development		128		
ER	Expense and Report Development	64		
ER1	Expense Uploads	16	Dev1	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
ER2	Uploaded Expenses Real-time Dashboard	4	ER1, BD6	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
ER3	AI-Extracted Expense Data Review and Correction	20	ER2	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
ER4	Uploaded Expenses Deletion	4	ER2	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
ER5	Expense Reports View, Creation, Edit, Submission, and Deletion	20	ER3, ER4	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
UA	User Access Development	64		

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ID	Name	Time (h)	Dependencies	Resources
UA1	Company Email User Authentication	8	BD7	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
UA2	Role-based User Access	16	UA1	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
UA3	Submitted Report Approval and Rejection	8	ER5, UA2	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
UA4	Employee Spending Limit Configuration	8	UA2	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
UA5	Submitted and Reviewed Expenses Record Visualization	4	UA3	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
UA6	Email Notification Service Integration	20	UA3	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
BD	Backend Development	120		
BD1	RESTful API Backend Logic Implementation	20	Dev1	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
BD2	Azure SQL Database Integration and Manipulation	20	BD1	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
BD3	Azure Blob Storage Integration	8	BD2	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
BD4	Microsoft Document Intelligence AI Model Integration	20	BD2, BD3	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
BD5	Automated AI-driven Data Extraction Pipeline	20	BD4	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
BD6	Azure SignalR Real-time Notification Service Integration	16	BD5	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
BD7	Microsoft Entra ID User Authentication Integration	16	BD1	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
FD	Frontend Development	10		
FD1	Expenses Search and Filter	8	ER2	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
FD2	Reports Search	2	ER5	DT, OS, HW, GIT, AZR, VSC, WEB
Total		513		

Table 5.3.1: Summary of project tasks with effort, dependencies, and resources. [Own creation]

5.4 Gantt Diagram

A Gantt diagram is attached at the end of this section. Continuous arrows represent Finish-Start (FS) dependencies between tasks, while dashed arrows represent Finish-Finish (FF) dependencies. FS dependencies indicate that successor tasks cannot start until their predecessor tasks are completed. FF dependencies show that successor tasks cannot finish until their predecessor tasks are completed.

Referring to Diagram 5.4.1, the project timeline spans **122 days** with a **one-week built-in buffer**. Considering the 513 total estimated hours, this equates to approximately **4 hours of work per day**. Consequently, the weekly workload is 28 hours, matching the weekly effort allocated in the Gantt diagram. Hence, the task effort estimations from Table 5.3.1 are translated into the Gantt diagram using this pattern (e.g., the ER1 task, which costs 20 hours, represents 4 days of work in the diagram).

According to Section 4.1, regular meetings with the Product Owner are arranged every two days. Considering each meeting takes around 30 minutes, and that the project timeline spans 122 days, a total of 30.5 hours is dedicated to the **PM1** task. Consequently, these iterative meetings occur on the full Gantt diagram timeline, and **should be represented iteratively** as well. However, since the diagram tool does not support this behavior, it is represented as a single concurrent task.

Excluding PM1, several other tasks are represented as concurrent, which corresponds to their actual occurrence:

- **PM2** remains undetermined due to undefined thesis director meetings, representing iterative appointments throughout the project lifetime.
- **PM3** starts after **PS2** (temporal planning) is completed and runs concurrently with full application development, as the product backlog requires constant updates whenever new features or tasks are added.
- **FPD2** runs over the project stage to ensure consistency with final deliverables.
- **Dev5**, which depends on **Dev1** (beginning once the repository is created), spans most of the project duration to satisfy objective SO5 from Section 3.1, as clean code requires ongoing, extensive documentation.

Certain development tasks also demand additional time. These tasks have an initial effort estimation of **8 hours (2 days of the Gantt diagram)**. Since these tasks face a high probability of experiencing significant challenges, the **remaining effort time** is allocated as a **buffer**.

Notable examples include **ER1**, **ER3**, **UA2**, and **UA6**. **ER1**. **ER1** is the first coding task; **ER3** requires extensive coordination with frontend and backend; **UA2** requires a prior database record of the employee hierarchy; **UA6** marks the author's first experience implementing email notifications. Finally, **Backend Development** tasks similarly incur additional time costs.

Expenses Reporting Tool for an IT Consultancy

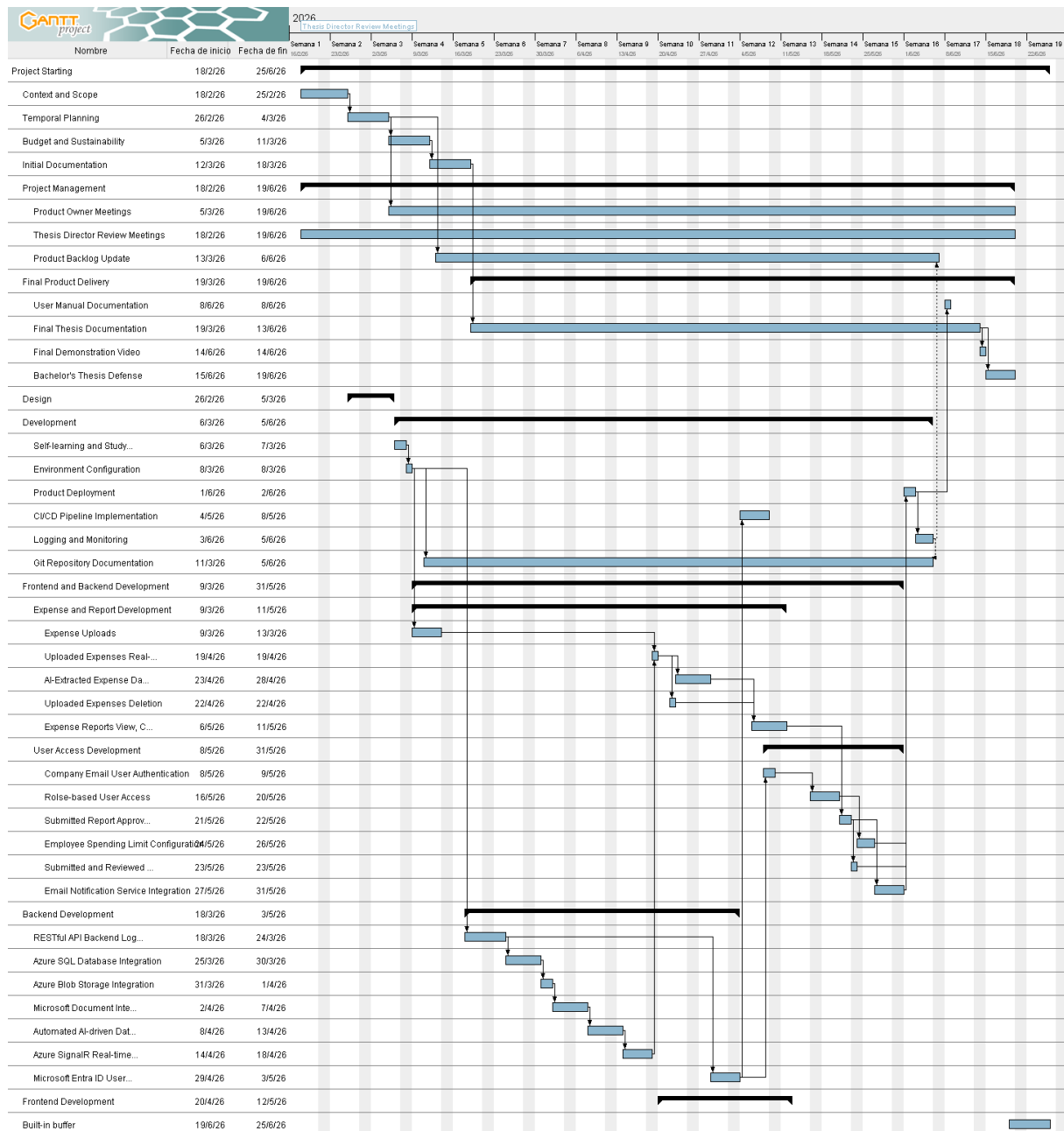


Figure 5.4.1: Gantt Diagram. [Own creation]

5.5 Risk Management

Possible risks affecting project progress are outlined in Section 3.3. With the timeline now established, contingency plans are defined to mitigate potential obstacles. This section presents each identified risk along with its probability, impact, and corresponding mitigation strategy. Moreover, all identified risks, along with the corresponding affected tasks and the contingency resources required for mitigation, are detailed in Table 5.5.1.

Coding Bugs

Probability: Medium

Impact: High

Coding bugs are inevitable, making thorough testing essential. As outlined in Section 4.3, every code change undergoes rigorous testing through automated CI/CD pipelines, including unit and integration tests. During the Dev1 task, ESLint and SonarQube Visual Studio Code extensions are installed to automate bug detection from the very beginning of the implementation.

If bugs persist, additional debugging time is allocated, using **10 hours** of the buffer time. It is important to fix critical bugs before proceeding with new feature development, prioritizing functional application delivery.

However, thanks to the installed extensions and consistent testing, the number of bugs is minimized, reducing the likelihood of significant setbacks. Furthermore, complex tasks already include built-in buffer time, as mentioned in section 5.4, and the reserve hours are available to cover any delays that may arise.

Tight Project Deadlines

Probability: High

Impact: Medium

Software development projects often struggle with tight deadlines. Due to the author's limited professional experience, deviation between the actual task effort and the initial time estimation is anticipated. However, since this project follows Agile methodology, iterative meetings help to detect and manage overruns at an early stage.

To overcome this challenge, the remaining **9 hours** of overhead serve as a lifesaver. This is an intentional allocation, as the project is scheduled to finish several days before the thesis defense period. Therefore, a one-week delay is permitted without affecting the final submission.

In the worst-case scenario, if the project misses the expected deadline, a selection of non-essential features, based on the MoSCoW prioritization defined in Section 3.2.1, will be deferred to the final development phase. As a result, these tasks will be completed only if time permits. This alternative may be adopted solely with the Product Owner's approval.

Lack of Experience in Certain Technologies

Probability: High

Impact: Medium

Given that several technologies used in application implementation lie beyond the author's expertise, mitigation plans have been established to address this challenge. Task Dev0 specifically accounts for this difficulty by allocating dedicated time for self-study, thereby minimizing potential setbacks.

Since a prior study cannot fully mitigate this risk, a proposed solution is to set aside up to **8 hours** from the available buffer. If delays are prolonged, assistance from the FSP team serves as a fallback. Seeking timely assistance is an essential professional skill, as it helps prevent unnecessary deadline extensions.

Company's Licenses and Security Permissions

Probability: Medium

Impact: Low

Another risk involves FSP's security system. Cyberattacks are taken more seriously every day, often requiring developers to request and wait for permission to install resources and extensions. Consequently, new restrictions may limit initial resource availability.

To prevent this blocker, Dev1 has been created to install all the previously identified tools and extensions in advance. However, this prior setup does not remove the probability of installing forthcoming tools.

As a contingency, a reordering of the project backlog can be considered using the Gantt chart (Figure 5.4.1) as a reference. Tasks with no dependencies, such as BD7 and the subsequent UA category tasks, may be prioritized and initialized earlier. Likewise, other non-dependent tasks (e.g., Dev5 task) may also be advanced to maintain project progress.

Risk	Probability	Time (h)	Affected Tasks	Resources
Coding Bugs	15%	10	Dev3, ER1-5, UA1-6, BD1-7, FD1-2	DT, HW
Tight Project Deadlines	30%	9	Dev2-4, ER1-5, UA1-6, BD1-7, FD1-2	DT, HW
Lack of Experience in Certain Technologies	30%	8	Dev2, Dev3, ER1-5, UA1-6, BD1-7,	DT, HW
Company's Licenses and Security Permissions	15%	0	Dev2, BD1-7	DT, HW

Table 5.5.1: Summary of identified risks, their probabilities, affected tasks, and contingency duration and resources. [Own creation]

6 Budget and Sustainability

The final fundamental aspect for concluding the initial documentation of a project is the budget and the project's economic viability. In addition, it is important to analyse the project's sustainability, considering the impact of the proposed solution on economic, environmental, and social dimensions. This stage studies both positive and negative project consequences.

6.1 Budget

This section details all project expenses, justifying each cost and its corresponding calculation. The ultimate goal is to determine the initial project budget.

6.1.1 Personnel Cost

To obtain realistic personnel cost estimates, the average hourly wage for each personnel member was calculated in advance using market salary data [9]. This calculation assumes 260 working days per year with an average of 7.5 working hours per day.

In Table 6.1.1, the hourly wage calculation for each member of personnel is specified. Note that the final number already includes the Social Security (SS) cost. Also note that personnel are categorized by roles rather than by the human resources (HR) identified in Section 5.2.1. Each resource is assigned to at least one role in the table. There are five different roles involved in this project:

- **Project Manager (PM)**: Responsible for planning and leading the entire project.
- **Junior Full-Stack Developer (D)**: Responsible for the full coding implementation of the application
- **QA Tester (T)**: Responsible for verifying the applications' functionality.
- **Software Architect (SA)**: Responsible for designing the application's technical structure while considering the project requirements and scope.
- **Technical Writer (TW)**: Responsible for elaborating a clear and accurate project documentation.

Role	Annual Salary (€)	Total including SS (€)	Cost / Hour (€)	Assigned HR
Project Manager (PM)	43,300	56,290	28.87	PO, TD, GT
Full-stack Junior Developer (D)	29,800	38,740	19.87	DT
QA Tester (T)	26,888	34,954.4	17.93	DT
Software Architect (SA)	41,800	54,340	27.87	DT
Technical Writer (TW)	31,300	40,690	20.87	DT

Table 6.1.1: Annual and hourly salaries for different project roles. [Own creation]

In Table 6.1.2, personnel costs for each task and role, as well as the overall cost, are calculated. These costs result from multiplying each personnel member's effort hours (from Table 5.3.1) by their corresponding role's hourly wage (from Table 6.1.1).

ID	Name	Total hours	Hours per role					Cost (€)
			PM	D	T	SA	TW	
PS	Project Starting	50	80	0	0	0	0	1,433.33
PS1	Context and Scope	20	20	0	0	0	0	577.33
PS2	Temporal Planning	10	10	0	0	0	0	288.67
PS3	Budget and Sustainability	10	10	0	0	0	0	288.67
PS4	Initial Documentation	10	10	0	0	0	0	288.67
PM	Project Management	46.5	38.5	46.5	0	0	0	2,035.17
PM1	Product Owner Meetings	30.5	30.5	30.5	0	0	0	1486.37
PM2	Thesis Director Review Meetings	8	8	8	0	0	0	389.87
PM3	Product Backlog Update	8	0	8	0	0	0	158.93
DT	Design	16	0	0	0	16	0	445.87
DT1	Use Case Diagram	2	0	0	0	2	0	55.73
DT2	Conceptual Model Diagram	4	0	0	0	4	0	111.47
DT3	Technology Stack Decision	2	0	0	0	2	0	55.73
DT4	Logic and Physic Architecture Design	4	0	0	0	4	0	111.47
DT5	UI mockups Design	2	0	0	0	2	0	55.73
DT6	Security Design	2	0	0	0	2	0	55.73
FPD	Final Product Delivery	56.5	0	5	0	0	51.5	1173.97
FPD1	User Manual Documentation	2	0	1	0	0	1	40.73
FPD2	Final Thesis Documentation	30.5	0	0	0	0	30.5	636.43
FPD3	Final Demonstration Video	4	0	4	0	0	0	79.47
FPD4	Bachelor's Thesis Defense	20	0	0	0	0	20	417.33
Dev	Development	86	0	76	10	0	0	1689.12
Dev0	Self-learning and study of unfamiliar technologies	8	0	8	0	0	0	158.93
Dev1	Environment Configuration	2	0	2	0	0	0	39.73
Dev2	Product Deployment	8	0	8	0	0	0	158.93
Dev3	CI/CD Pipeline Implementation	20	0	10	10	0	0	377.92
Dev4	Logging and Monitoring	8	0	8	0	0	0	158.93
Dev5	Git Repository Documentation	40	0	40	0	0	0	794.67
Frontend and Backend Development		128	0	128	0	0	0	2,542.93
ER	Expense and Report Development	64	0	64	0	0	0	1,271.47
ER1	Expense Uploads	16	0	16	0	0	0	317.87
ER2	Uploaded Expenses Real-time Dashboard	4	0	4	0	0	0	79.47
ER3	AI-Extracted Expense Data Review and Correction	20	0	20	0	0	0	397.33
ER4	Uploaded Expenses Deletion	4	0	4	0	0	0	79.47
ER5	Expense Reports View, Creation, Edit, Submission, and Deletion	20	0	20	0	0	0	397.33

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ID	Name	Total hours	Hours per role					Cost (€)
			PM	D	T	SA	TW	
UA	User Access Development	64	0	64	0	0	0	1,271.47
UA1	Company Email User Authentication	8	0	8	0	0	0	158.93
UA2	Role-based User Access	16	0	16	0	0	0	317.87
UA3	Submitted Report Approval and Rejection	8	0	8	0	0	0	158.93
UA4	Employee Spending Limit Configuration	8	0	8	0	0	0	158.93
UA5	Submitted and Reviewed Expenses Record Visualization	4	0	4	0	0	0	79.47
UA6	Email Notification Service Integration	20	0	20	0	0	0	397.33
BD	Backend Development	120	0	120	0	0	0	2,384.00
BD1	RESTful API Backend Logic Implementation	20	0	20	0	0	0	397.33
BD2	Azure SQL Database Integration and Manipulation	20	0	20	0	0	0	397.33
BD3	Azure Blob Storage Integration	8	0	8	0	0	0	158.93
BD4	Microsoft Document Intelligence AI Model Integration	20	0	20	0	0	0	397.33
BD5	Automated AI-driven Data Extraction Pipeline	20	0	20	0	0	0	397.33
BD6	Azure SignalR Real-time Notification Service Integration	16	0	16	0	0	0	317.87
BD7	Microsoft Entra ID User Authentication Integration	16	0	16	0	0	0	317.87
FD	Frontend Development	10	0	10	0	0	0	198.67
FD1	Expenses Search and Filter	8	0	8	0	0	0	158.93
FD2	Reports Search	2	0	2	0	0	0	39.73
Total		513	88.5	385.5	10	16	51.5	11,913.05

Table 6.1.2: Personnel cost breakdown by task, role, and total personnel cost. [Own creation]

6.1.2 Generic Cost

In addition to personnel costs, other project costs must also be considered. Therefore, the missing costs are detailed in this section, followed by the formula applied to obtain the resulting cost.

Amortization

Physical resources are also required and used in the project. However, considering only the product purchase price would not be entirely correct. For this reason, the depreciation of each hardware resource has been calculated.

Hardware resources have a 4-year depreciation period. Other relevant factors for amortization calculation include the total project duration and the number of hours dedicated to the project each day, respectively 122 days and 4 hours per day. Since the hardware resources are used throughout the project timeline, their total usage time corresponds to the total project hours (513 hours). Accordingly, the subsequent equation calculates the amortization costs for each hardware resource shown in Table 6.1.3:

$$\text{Amortization (€)} = \text{Resource price} \times \frac{1}{4 \text{ years}} \times \frac{1}{122 \text{ days}} \times \frac{1}{4 \text{ hours}} \times \text{hours used}$$

Hardware Resources	Price (€)	Quantity	Total Price (€)	Usage Time (h)	Amortization (€)
PC Dell 16 Pro [10]	1,193.53	1	1,193.53	513	313.67
Wireless Mouse [11]	11.99	1	16.99	513	4.47
Dell Monitor [12]	171.82	2	343.64	513	90.31
Keyboard [13]	19.99	1	19.99	513	5.25
Total					408.44

Table 6.1.3: Amortization cost of the project's hardware resources. [Own creation]

Electric cost

The current cost of electricity is around **0.1748 €/kWh** [14]. Electricity costs are calculated based solely on the electricity-consuming hardware resources and their respective usage times. Following the same approach used for amortization cost calculation, the usage time is **513 hours**. Table 6.1.4 details the calculations and the resulting total cost:

Hardware Resources	Power (W)	Usage Time (h)	Energy Consumed (kWh)	Electricity Cost (€)
PC Dell 16 Pro [10]	65	513	33.345	5.83
Wireless Mouse [11]	0.05	513	0.02565	0.00
Dell Monitor [12]	24	513	12.312	2.15
Keyboard [13]	0.1	513	0.0513	0.01
Total				7.99

Table 6.1.4: Electricity cost of the project's hardware resources. [Own creation]

Internet cost

The basic internet plan costs €21.95 per month [15]. Since the project lasts 122 days, the internet cost is calculated as follows:

$$\text{Internet cost} = 21.95 \text{ €/month} \times \frac{1 \text{ month}}{30 \text{ days}} \times 122 \text{ days} = \mathbf{€89.26}$$

Travel cost

The public transport rate in Barcelona is 45.5€ per 3 months [16]; the total travel cost corresponds to the following equation:

$$\text{Travel cost} = 45.5 \text{ €/3 months} \times \frac{3 \text{ months}}{90 \text{ days}} \times 122 \text{ days} = \mathbf{€61.88}$$

Office rental cost

The project development always takes place in the FSP office. Therefore, this is the only cost to consider in this category. The FSP office is located in Plaça Francesc Macià, Barcelona. The monthly rental fee is €6,000. Given that there is enough space to accommodate up to 25 employees working at the same time, the total cost is calculated as follows:

$$\text{Office rental cost} = 6,000 \text{ €/month} \times \frac{1 \text{ month}}{30 \text{ days}} \times \frac{1 \text{ office}}{25 \text{ employees}} \times 122 \text{ days} = \mathbf{€976.00}$$

Software resources cost

Finally, the cost of software resources is also considered. However, most of them are open-source and therefore excluded from the total cost, as they are available for free. Only resources that require payment are listed below. Regarding Azure resources, only those that incur a cost are included, since Azure offers a pay-as-you-go fee [17]. See Table 6.1.5 for a detailed breakdown of the cost of Azure resources.

Azure resources	Cost (€/month)
SQL DataBase	3.90
Bandwidth	0.01
Blob Storage	0.01
Log Analytics	0.01
Event Grid	0.01
Service Bus	0.01
Functions	0.01
Total	3.96

Table 6.1.5: Azure resource cost. [Own creation]

Given that the Azure resource cost is €3.96 per month, the total cost for the project (122 days) is calculated as follows:

$$\text{Azure resource cost} = 3.96 \text{ €/month} \times \frac{1 \text{ month}}{30 \text{ days}} \times 122 \text{ days} = \mathbf{€24.16}$$

Microsoft is also included in the software resources cost, demanding an annual fee of €99 [18]. This resource cost is calculated in the next equation:

$$\text{Microsoft resource cost} = 99 \text{ €/year} \times \frac{1 \text{ year}}{365 \text{ days}} \times 122 \text{ days} = \mathbf{€33.09}$$

Thus, the total software resources cost equals the sum of both costs:

$$€24.16 + €33.09 = \mathbf{€57.25}$$

Total generic cost

By summing all previously calculated costs, the total generic cost is obtained, as shown in Table 6.1.6.

Concept	Cost (€)
Amortization	408.44
Electricity	7.99
Internet	89.26
Travel	61.68
Office Rental	976.00
Software	57.25
Generic Cost (GC)	1,600.63

Table 6.1.6: Total generic cost. [Own creation]

6.1.3 Other costs

Contingencies

No project strategy can eliminate the possibility of encountering obstacles. Therefore, a time buffer (27 hours) has been included to cover potential setbacks. However, simply adding extra time is insufficient, as it also entails additional resource consumption.

For this reason, a portion of the project budget must be allocated for these potential scenarios. The proportional buffer time allocated to the total project duration is 5% (27h/420). Therefore, the contingency cost amounts to **€675.68**, which is the 5% of the total general cost calculated so far:

$$PC (\text{€}) + GC (\text{€}) = 11,913.05 + 1,600.92 = \mathbf{13,513.68 \text{ €}}$$

Incidental Costs

Incidental costs encompass the project risks outlined in Section 5.5. The cost of each risk is calculated by considering its probability, time cost, and required resources. Table 6.1.7 details these calculations. Note that the resources required for each risk are identified as Rx (R1, R2, ...).

Incident	Risk (%)	Time (h)	R1	R1 Cost (€/h)	R2	R2 Cost (€/h)	Total Cost (€)	Risk Cost (€)
Coding Bugs	15	10	D	19.87	HW	7.96	206.63	30.99
Tight Project Deadlines	30	9	D	19.87	HW	7.17	185.97	55.79
Lack of Experience in Certain Technologies	30	8	D	19.87	HW	6.37	165.30	49.59
Company's Licenses and Security Permissions	15	0	D	19.87	HW	0.00	0.00	0.00
Total								136.37

Table 6.1.7: Incidental cost. [Own creation]

6.1.4 Total cost

After summing the total costs from each section, the final project budget is determined, as shown in Table 6.1.8.

Concept	Cost (€)
Personnel Cost (PC)	11,913.05
Generic Cost (GC)	1,600.63
Contingency Cost (CC)	675.68
Incidental Cost (IC)	136.37
Total Budget	14,325.74

Table 6.1.8: Total cost of the project. [Own creation]

6.1.5 Management Control

Challenges, both expected and unexpected, are always present in any project. Even with a precisely estimated timeline and budget, it is very common for a project to fall short of the initial plan. To monitor costs during project execution, various deviation formulas will be applied in the three areas:

- **Human resources deviation:** To contrast the actual effort with the previous estimated effort of human resources in each task.

$$\text{Human resources deviation} = \sum_{i \in pit} (\text{estimated_cost_per_hour}_i - \text{real_cost_per_hour}_i) \times \text{total_real_hours}_i$$

Where i indexes each individual in pit , the set of all personnel involved in that task.

- **Amortization deviation:** To compare the previously estimated use of hardware resources with the actual usage time of those resources.

$$\text{Amortization deviation} = \sum_{i \in hr} (\text{estimated_usage_hours}_i - \text{real_usage_hours}_i) \times \text{price_per_hour}_i$$

Where i indexes each resource in hr , the set of all hardware resources used in the project.

- **Total cost deviation:** To determine each task's real cost deviation from the estimated cost. The general cost described in the formula represents the sum of the personnel and generic costs, excluding contingency and incident costs. Hence, the following formula is applied to each task:

$$\text{Total cost deviation} = (\text{estimated_general_cost} - \text{real_general_cost})$$

All cost deviation calculations require the real project costs across different categories. Before applying the deviation formulas, the real costs are calculated at the end of the project using the same methodology as the initial budget estimation.

Note that the resulting total cost deviation value can be either positive or negative. A positive value indicates an overestimation of the initial budget for that resource or task. In this case, the additional budget can be reallocated to address issues that arise during the project. Conversely, a negative value indicates an underestimation, requiring contingency and incident costs to cover the budget shortfall.

6.2 Sustainability

The technological revolution has accelerated dramatically over the last few decades. A clear example is the launch of the first telephone (1876), the first computer (1937), the first laptop (1974), the first smartphone (2007), and the first artificial intelligence (2017) [19].

This acceleration pace reveals that the time it takes for a technological invention to emerge and significantly impact society continues to shrink. Consequently, this exponential growth underscores the increasing importance of evaluating the economic, environmental, and social impacts of technological projects. These three dimensions together constitute sustainability, the topic discussed in this section.

Building on this trend, technology will continue shaping our future in the coming years. The primary mission of every engineer is to make people's daily lives easier. However, as mentioned earlier, developing a solution is not enough; a study of its sustainability effects is also a must.

Therefore, this section addresses sustainability questions, enabling a better evaluation of the project's impact across the economy, environment, and society. This analysis raises awareness of the weight of sustainability in project development.

Personally, the author recognizes limited sustainability understanding. The knowledge extends only to well-known aspects such as environmental footprint and social impact. The economic dimension and multiple sustainability indicators require further study. The subsequent subsection answers a series of key sustainability questions within the author's current expertise.

6.2.1 Economic Impact

Regarding PPP: Have you estimated the project execution cost?

The project budget is detailed in Section 6.1. All required costs have been considered, including personnel, hardware, software, contingencies, and incidents. Only indispensable resources are used and are included in the budget.

The computer used throughout the project was recently purchased and remains under warranty. Since there is an overabundance of hardware resources in the office, they can be easily replaced if needed. Regarding the software resources, they were already available to the company and are virtual; as a consequence, fixes and repairs are not included in the budget.

Additionally, only essential tasks demand a higher time cost. Since the AI model is connected to an external resource, this development phase can be significantly reduced while obtaining accurate data extraction. From an objective standpoint, a meticulous budget estimate has been established.

Regarding Useful Life: How are currently solved economic issues (costs...) related to the problem that you want to address (state of the art)?

The current expense management process imposes an excessive time cost for employees, who manually enter expenses into Excel spreadsheets. The same challenge is encountered in the finance department, which must verify the accuracy of each line item before approving reimbursements. Additionally, the current process is prone to human error regarding manual expense data entry and review.

In short, this time-consuming, low-efficiency process delivers minimal value while misallocating company personnel costs for both employees and finance staff.

Regarding Useful Life: How will your solution improve economic issues (costs, etc.) with respect to other existing solutions?

The proposed solution automates the current cumbersome process. It provides automatic receipt data extraction and a more intuitive dashboard for displaying receipt information. This eliminates the tedious manual data entry, enhances visualization beyond traditional spreadsheets, and reduces human error. As a result, the workflow is significantly streamlined, delivering accurate receipt processing while maximizing efficiency. This enables employees to focus on higher-value tasks, thus maximizing personnel investment returns.

6.2.2 Environmental Impact

Regarding PPP: Have you estimated the project's environmental impact?

The only resource directly affecting the environmental footprint is energy consumption. This resource is required throughout the entire project, as specified in Section 6.1.2. Both hardware resources and the shared workspace consume electricity continuously. However, hardware resource consumption is vital for application development and sharing the workspace's lighting with other employees reduces its environmental impact.

Regarding PPP: Have you considered minimizing its impact, for example, by reusing resources?

The application uses Azure for software resources. Currently, the Azure resources required for application development cost less than traditional physical resources. This cost optimization results from significantly reduced resource consumption, as cloud resources eliminate the need for transportation and frequent physical replacements. Updates and fixes are performed virtually, further reducing hardware requirements and electronic waste.

Furthermore, training the AI model requires substantial energy consumption. Reusing existing solutions, as decided in this project, optimizes this energy-intensive development process. Hence, the entire application development process prevents excessive resource use. As a result, tasks can be significantly reduced while avoiding excessive time costs.

Regarding Useful Life: How is the problem that you want to address currently solved (state of the art)?

The extensive time employees and finance staff dedicate to Excel spreadsheets results in excessive energy use. Switching the personnel to process expenses in the application also requires an energy-saving approach.

The primary strategy for reducing resource consumption is to develop the most efficient application possible, avoiding unnecessary resources and inefficient code that could overuse resources. This ensures that only essential resources are consumed each time employees use the application, limiting overall resource consumption throughout its lifecycle. Therefore, writing high-quality code is an essential skill for a programmer and is strongly considered throughout the project development.

Regarding Useful Life: How will your solution improve the environment with respect to other existing solutions?

This application is tailored for the company's exclusive use and excludes any irrelevant functionality from the final product. It streamlines resource consumption by avoiding the unnecessary computation performed by other existing applications.

6.2.3 Social Impact

Regarding PPP: What do you think you will achieve—in terms of personal growth—from doing this project?

This project enables the author to apply prior academic knowledge and software development skills in a real-world context. As a result, it enriches their working experience as future software engineer. Furthermore, it is the author's first experience managing and leading an entire project independently, strengthening self-learning, self-management skills and the ability to build software projects from scratch.

Regarding Useful Life: How is the problem that you want to address currently solved (state of the art)?

The current expense management process is handled manually through traditional methods. This involves manually entering data into Excel spreadsheets, emailing them to the finance department, and reviewing them line by line.

Regarding Useful Life: How will your solution improve the quality of life (social dimension) with respect to other existing solutions?

The proposed solution optimizes time spent on expense management while reducing employees' frustration and fatigue. This frees employees from this tedious task, allowing additional time to focus on more meaningful work. As a result, it maximizes employees' productivity.

Regarding Useful Life: Is there a real need for the project?

Regarding all project sustainability impacts (social, environmental, and economic), there is a clear need to build a robust solution. This solution overcomes challenges from all involved parties while introducing a sustainability-focused approach.

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